

THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

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Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Into a quiet room.

A kettle not long boiled. On the side table, two mugs. One steams. The other, further off, is stone cold with a skin on it. It has been there a while.

MAYA, 30s, on the sofa in her coat, a book face down on her knee. JAMES, 30s, in the little kitchen, unhurried, at home in it.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. Something in him eases. A body that has decided it isn't alone.

JAMES

There was a heron on the tarn this morning. Same spot as yesterday. Just stood there.

MAYA

Mm.

JAMES

Hours, probably. Didn't move.

MAYA

You said we'd talk when we got here. That was the deal. We drove three hours.

JAMES

We're talking.

MAYA
You're telling me about a bird.

He rinses a mug. A third one, not either of the two on the table. Sets it on the rack.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Come and sit down. Please.

JAMES
In a sec.

He wipes the counter. It is already clean.

MAYA
You've wiped that twice.

JAMES
It's a rental.

MAYA
(letting it go, not
letting it go)
You talked about that heron for ten minutes in the car. I timed it. Ten minutes on a bird standing in a lake.

JAMES
You asked what I did yesterday.

MAYA
I did. You're right. I did ask.

She looks at the cold mug with the skin on it.

MAYA (CONT'D)
That's been there since this morning.

JAMES
I'll get it.

He doesn't. He dries his hands instead, and comes through, and sits. Not next to her. The armchair. The small distance registers on her face.

He settles in. And then, quiet, almost nothing, to the empty end of the sofa nearest him, the ghost of a smile:

JAMES (CONT'D)
(barely)
Move up, then.

Maya goes still.

MAYA
What did you say.

JAMES
Nothing.

MAYA
You said move up.

JAMES
I didn't say anything.

She looks at the empty end of the sofa. At the cushion he said it to.

MAYA
(quiet)
There's no one there.

JAMES
I know there's no one there.

MAYA
Do you.

He rubs his face. For half a second he isn't sure. Then it passes and he's just tired again.

MAYA (CONT'D)
I booked this place so we could...
I don't even know. I think I
thought if the walls were different
you'd be different.

JAMES
I'm right here.

MAYA
You keep saying that like it's the
same thing as being here.

He gets up. Restless. Crosses to the window and opens it.
Cold air moves into the room.

MAYA (CONT'D)
(up, crossing, petty)
Oh my God, it's freezing, it's a
stone box on a hill, I'm in a coat.

She shuts it herself. Hard. Stands there a second, back to him, getting her breath.

Then, not turning:

MAYA (CONT'D)
You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES
Here we go.

MAYA
And you made the second one sweet.
Two sugars. You don't take sugar.

Silence.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Fifteen years I've known you. You
stood there this morning and put
two sugars in a cup and stirred it
and I watched you and I didn't say
anything, because what am I
supposed to...

She doesn't finish it.

JAMES
I wasn't thinking.

MAYA
No. You were. That's the thing. You
measured it out exactly right for
someone who isn't...

She stops again. Neither of them says the word.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Is it someone.

JAMES
What?

MAYA
Just tell me if it's someone. A
person. I swear I could stand it.
Give me a name and an address and
I'll go and I'll fight her, I would
rather that, I would so much rather
that than--

JAMES
It isn't someone.

MAYA
Then what is it. What is it, James.

JAMES
(tired, unkind)
You think I've got the energy for
an affair.

MAYA
No. No, I don't. That's what
frightens me.

She crosses. Takes his face in both her hands. Makes him
look at her.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Am I still here. Do you actually
see me.

He looks at her. And for a second he is all there,
completely, and it is awful how much she needs that second.

Then his eyes slip. Past her. To nothing. She feels his face
pull toward it under her hands.

She lets go.

MAYA (CONT'D)
You leave your own eyes. Nobody
tells you that can happen. He'll be
looking right at me and he'll just
go. Out the back of his own face.

Beat. She is too tired to hold it in.

MAYA (CONT'D)
I am so tired. I am so tired of
being married to a headstone.

It lands. It is too far, and she knows it the instant it is
out of her.

MAYA (CONT'D)
I didn't mean--

JAMES
(quiet)
Yeah, you did.

She has no answer to that. He is right.

MAYA
You could put it down. You know.
Any of it. You could just...

She can't land the sentence. She doesn't try to make it
pretty.

MAYA (CONT'D)
You won't, though.

JAMES
(barely)
It isn't that simple.

MAYA
I know. I know it isn't. I do know
that.

Something gives in him. He crosses to her, fast, not gentle. It is a collision more than an embrace. She shoves him hard in the chest, then fists his shirt and pulls him back in. Rage and want, no daylight between them.

She bites his shoulder. He makes a sound. He holds her too hard, his face turned away over her head, his eyes open. Finding the space.

JAMES
(into her hair)
I'm trying. I don't think you have
any idea how hard I'm--

MAYA
Trying to stay. You can't even
manage that.

He goes very still against her. His eyes fixed on the empty air.

JAMES
(almost to himself)
I don't even know if you're--

He can't finish it. He does not know who he is asking, or whether anyone is there to ask.

He lets go of her. Steps back. Drifts to the window and opens it again, without knowing he is doing it. The cold comes back in.

MAYA
You opened it again.

He doesn't hear her. His hand comes up. Reaching toward the nothing beside him. Palm open. At a height. As if to find a shoulder that should be there.

His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. What he is doing. The reach. The two mugs. The cold sweet coffee. The empty end of the sofa. Maya. Himself. The whole shape of it at once, laid out like evidence.

His face comes apart.

JAMES
(barely)
No.

His arm sweeps the side table. The cold mug hits the floor and smashes.

MAYA
(flinching back)
James.

He isn't looking at her. He is looking at the empty air. He backs away from it, and it follows him, gentle, closer, not understanding.

JAMES
(low, pleading, to no one
she can see)
Not now. Not tonight. Go on.
Please. Go.

MAYA
(barely a whisper)
Who are you talking to.

JAMES
(a roar, ragged, at
nothing at all)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. A hard rush back, away from him, across the room, over the broken mug, out through the open window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELLS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing hard. The gold window shrinking beneath it.

The mountains. The dark. All that empty country.

It stops, high above the roof. Looks down.

Down at the little lit cottage. Down at the one warm window with the man in it. Small now. Both hands over his face.

And Maya, frozen behind him. Staring at the man she loves shaking at an empty room, a smashed cup at his feet, and nothing there. Nothing at all.

The camera holds in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look back at a place you have just been thrown out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.